

From the Editor

Hans Georg Gemünden, Dr. rer. oec. habil., Chair for Technology and Innovation Management, Technische Universität Berlin, Berlin, Germany



Photo credit: Markus Bullick

This issue of *PMJ* presents a very interesting article from Johann Packendorff, Lucia Crevani, and Monica Lindgren who take a process view on project leadership in an organizational change project. They do not concentrate on a given leader who exerts a certain leadership behavior; rather, they take a processual view of how leadership is becoming during a project. This article is not only remarkable because of its different conceptualization of leadership, but also because of the ethnographic approach it uses for its comprehensive empirical analysis. I see three major themes in project and program management, which deserve further research and quality publications: (1) Megaprojects, which are delivered externally from a network of suppliers to a customer organization; (2) management of complex project landscapes, i.e., multi-project management; and (3) management of major organizational transformations. The article offers a new, interesting conceptual lens and an interesting empirical method for the analyses of such cases.

The next two papers have to do with major changes in how projects are organized, particularly in the software and media industries. Agile methodologies are intensively diffusing and used in new application areas, and new forms of agile are being developed; additionally, hybrids of conventional process methodologies and agile methodologies are discussed and applied. The paper from Edivandro Carlos Conforto and coauthors offers the results of a survey, which documents the situation in Brazil and how barriers in traditional industries can be overcome. The other paper on agile methodologies comes from Michael Jahr; it offers a formalized quantitative analysis and shows how the performance of agile can be assessed and that hybrid strategies offer better results. The review process for this paper was done by my colleague and departmental editor, Gary Klein, who had to reject many quantitative papers because they were not sufficiently current. This paper, however, is current and has a high practical value for this emerging new management approach because it provides a quantitative assessment and demonstrates the value of hybrid solutions.

The next two papers are action research papers. The paper from Chivonne Algeo concentrates more on the

methodological aspects of applying this approach in the context of knowledge management. Her systematic analysis got the prize for the best student paper at IRNOP in Oslo last year. The paper from Thierry Gidel, Gaël Buet, and Dominique Millet is much more pragmatic; it develops a method on how to assess the difficulty of integration in a vehicle-independent innovation project, from the pool of predevelopment projects, with a potential new vehicle project, and how to derive recommendations from this on how intensively and how early in the process integrative communication and planning activities should take place. Their hypothesis is: The needs for integration are not constant; rather, they vary considerably. They develop a measure for the construct “intrusiveness” and, depending on the value of this indicator, they offer varied recommendations on how to organize the integration process. This is a really well done study with high practical value. Based on some insight into the German automotive industry, I can say that the integration need is also clearly recognized, but the integration measures are much more static, following the saying, “one size fits all.”

The sixth and final paper from Rebecca Yang, Yaowu Wang, and Xiao-Hua Jin is a very interesting empirical study on stakeholders’ attributes, behaviors, and decision-making strategies in construction projects.

Following are abstracts of the papers in this issue. Have fun reading!

In the **first paper** “*Project Leadership in Becoming: A Process Study of an Organizational Change Project*” by **Johann Packendorff**, KTH Royal Institute of Technology, Stockholm, Sweden; **Lucia Crevani**, Mälardalen University, Västerås, Sweden; and **Monica Lindgren**, KTH Royal Institute of Technology, Stockholm, Sweden, the authors develop and apply a process ontology to the study of project leadership.

First, the theoretical implications of a process ontology as applied to project leadership are discussed, outlining an analytical framework in which the on going construction of action space and project direction is seen as involving constructions of project paths, positions, issues, and rhythms. Afterward, the framework was applied to a process study of an organizational change project in which a U.S. management control regulation was implemented in the Swedish subsidiary of a multinational chemical firm.

The authors argue that project leadership work can be studied as a series of social activities and events in which actors, projects, and organizational contexts are all in constant and mutually interacting flux, rather than as traits, styles, and competences of individual project managers.

The **second paper** by **Edivandro Carlos Conforto**, Massachusetts Institute of Technology; **Fabian Ariel Salum**, Fundação Dom Cabral, Minas Gerais; **Sérgio Luis da Silva**, Federal University of São Carlos; **Daniel Capaldo Amaral**, University of São Paulo; and **Luis Fernando Magnanini de Almeida**, Federal University of São Carlos, Brazil: *Can Agile Project Management Be Adopted by Industries Other than Software Development?* investigates the use of agile project management (APM) practices and the presence of APM enablers in various industries.

In the past, the software industry has been the main focus of the flexible APM approach; thus, this study presents a conceptual framework to address the identification of practices and enablers related to the APM approach to find evidence of APM in other industrial sectors. The framework was applied in an exploratory survey within 19 Brazilian medium and large-sized companies that have experience in new product development projects but do not yet formally recognize the use of APM methods.

Results indicate evidence of favorable aspects to implementing APM, as the presence of some APM enablers indicates opportunities to adapt the APM theory for different companies. Further, the study also identified potential barriers for APM implementation in more “traditional industries.” Consequently, the authors propose the hypothesis that the APM approach could be adapted to non-software companies, at least for innovative projects, and suggest further research to explore the correlation between APM practices and enablers aimed at developing “hybrid” management models for companies beyond the software industry.

The **third paper** *“A Hybrid Approach to Quantitative Software Project Scheduling Within Agile Frameworks”* from **Michael Jahr**, European University of Applied Sciences, Neuss, Germany, focuses on the quantitative project scheduling problem in IT companies that apply the agile management philosophy.

This article combines mathematical programming with an agile project flow, using a modified multi-mode resource constrained project scheduling model for software projects. Hereby, it is shown that agile methods and traditional approaches are not contrary ways and that quantitative models are a useful support to project management in agile frameworks.

The proposed approach can be used to generate schedules as benchmarks for agile development iterations. Further, tests showed that using a hybrid approach with a modified process flowchart can significantly improve the adherence to deadlines and budgets and reduce the project cycle time.

The **fourth paper** by **Chivonne Algeo**, University of Technology Sydney–DAB, Sydney, Australia, is *“Exploring Project Knowledge Acquisition and Exchange Through Action Research.”*

The qualitative study was conducted with six project managers based in public or private organizations in Australia, using interviews and observations to understand how project managers acquire and exchange knowledge when they are managing projects. Data were collected through three action research cycles in which the existing situation was examined, reflected upon, and changes were implemented and then evaluated over eighteen months. Hereby, the analysis made use of grounded theory techniques.

To examine how project managers acquire and exchange knowledge, multiple perspectives were sought. These perspectives represented what the participants said they did to exchange knowledge; what they actually did when being observed; and what their work colleagues said they did when managing projects.

The **fifth paper** in this issue *“Synchronization of Innovation and Vehicle Projects: Proposal of a Management Tool at Renault SAS”* is from **Thierry Gidel**, Université de Technologie de Compiègne, Picardie, France; **Gaël Buet**, Renault SAS, Guyancourt, France; and **Dominique Millet**, Université de Toulon, Cote d’Azur, France.

To remain competitive, the automotive industry must innovate to fulfill demanding customers. Therefore, a better control of the innovation process is necessary and especially crucial for the integration of these innovations into vehicle projects, as well as supporting the understanding and anticipation of the decisions and choices of all actors involved.

The article discusses the steps toward the creation of a supporting management tool by demonstrating the importance of the identification and synchronization step for improving the amount and quality of innovation projects in vehicle projects. Hereby, the authors introduce the management tool “Profilor,” which is based on the concept of intrusiveness and aims to manage the interplay between innovation projects and vehicle projects. The objectives are to increase and optimize the amount and value of innovation projects integrated into vehicle projects.

A key element in the study is the flexible innovation process. Although organizations tend to define innovation processes that are supposed to be implemented within the company, the authors demonstrate that, in addition to the classical “long-term” innovation process, a “fast track” innovation process should be implemented. This flexible approach, however, is in need of even more interactions between the departments.

The **sixth and final paper** in this issue by **Rebecca Yang**, RMIT University, Melbourne, Australia; **Yaowu Wang**, Harbin Institute of Technology, Harbin, China; and **Xiao-Hua Jin**, University of Western Sydney, Australia: *“Stakeholders’*

Attributes, Behaviors, and Decision-Making Strategies in Construction Projects: Importance and Correlations in Practice” is based on three research questions: (1) Which stakeholder behaviors are more distinct in construction practice? (2) Which decision-making strategies are mostly used in construction projects? And (3) Do the answers of the aforementioned two questions vary according to project types?

The study was conducted in three phases with interviews, a questionnaire survey, and a case study as the primary research methods. Hereby, six interviews with industrial professionals were conducted in the first phase, and 183 questionnaires completed in the second phase. The last phase

involved another 15 interviews with construction practitioners to verify the outcomes of the previous phases.

Findings suggest that three stakeholder attributes (power, urgency, and proximity) and four types of stakeholder behaviors (cooperative potential, competitive threat, opposite position, and neutral attitude) are perceived by practitioners as important to dealing with stakeholders’ claims. Further, research indicates that to deal with stakeholders with a competitive threat or neutral attitude, project managers need to communicate and negotiate with them more. Overall, engaging stakeholders regularly and establishing long-term relationships are considered critical for successful management.